

Exchange order changes the total

Chess Math

THE IDEA

When several pieces attack a square, changing the capture order changes which piece is exposed to recapture. A low-value attacker is often a useful starting point, but checks, pins, and intermediate moves can reverse the usual order.

WORKED EXAMPLE

A pawn and queen both attack an enemy rook. If either can capture safely, a pawn capture risks less material. If the queen capture gives forced mate, king safety overrides that ordinary cost comparison.

TRY IT BEFORE READING ON

Why is 'always capture with the cheapest piece' too strong?

ANSWER AND REASONING

A cheaper capture may release a pin, block your own line, or miss a forcing check. Compare the resulting positions after each legal sequence rather than applying a fixed rule.

TAKE THIS INTO YOUR NEXT GAME

Use value order as a hypothesis to calculate.